



Game Design as Worldbuilding: Interactive Worlds and Imaginative Acts in LARP

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Abstract

LARP (Live Action RolePlaying) games are often characterized by simulated combat encounters in order to progress the plot of the game or resolve the conflict. While this is not an inherent flaw of the game, a focus on combat can detract from player engagement with the worldbuilding and story of the game by emphasizing physical activity over cognitive interaction. Along with a group of IMGD students I built a world and then ran a short LARP quest set in that

world in order to test (1) how the story could be told without combat and (2) whether removing the option for fighting would improve the players' interaction with the world. My design goal was to help draw attention to the imagined world through puzzles and interactions with Non-Player-Characters (NPCs) rather than being obscured by combat. Without a constant draw towards combat, players were able to interact with the world of the quest more deeply and learned more about the lore than a standard combat-centered quest allows for.

Introduction

If you have ever played a game like Dungeons and Dragons, or played pretend as a child that you were a knight going to slay a dragon, you have been part of a roleplaying experience. Roleplaying is any form of game or activity where a player pretends to be someone else during the game. Live Action RolePlay games (LARPs) are one type of roleplaying game where the players pretend to be their characters in a real space. LARP is an adult form of playing pretend, where quests to fight a monster or save a prisoner are some of the most common activities. But LARP has the chance to have much deeper worlds and stories—as long as players are able to see those worlds and stories. LARPs have a tendency to obscure their worlds with game mechanics like simulated combat which can hide the story and prevent players from experiencing it. However, even a LARP intended to be run with combat can be designed to limit the fighting and better allow players to experience the world and story of the quest.

Background

What is Worldbuilding?

Worldbuilding is a term often thrown around when discussing epic fantasy, science fiction, or other stories set in a fully fictional world, but it rarely comes with a definition. Even when an author provides a definition it rarely agrees with other definitions. In their piece on how to critically analyze worldbuilding Audrey Taylor and Stefan Ekman claim that “for authors, world-building is a sequential, iterative, and segmental process: the adding, changing, or developing of elements by various strategies. Such strategies may comprise mapmaking,

extrapolation, and designing a world along certain ideological lines.”¹ These processes are some of the basic steps required for worldbuilding as an action. Beyond that, worldbuilding can also be a noun representing the descriptions of a world. Emily Temple writes that worldbuilding is “the existence of an internal logic, mood, or yes, set of descriptions that gives their work a sense of context.”² That can mean that worldbuilding is a full description of a world, from the smallest insect, to the orbital mechanics of the solar system the planet resides in. Most of those details do not directly affect the plot, but instead create the appearance of a full world that the story takes place in. Kaitlin Tremblay says that “[w]orldbuilding is the ground that character and story grow out of, and that is because characters and worldbuilding exist in parallel with each other, not against.”³ Each of the aspects of the world work together to form the entire world, and without any of them the world is incomplete. The plot of the story then builds onto the world, and adds to it. Sequential stories set in a world can therefore use the earlier stories as part of the worldbuilding. This means that as people write in the worlds they have created the worldbuilding is constantly evolving. Tremblay also says that “Worldbuilding is composed of all the physical parts of a place, but all the intangible aspects as well, such as culture, belief, interpersonal relationships, and so forth.”⁴ It is not just the maps of a world or the people and wildlife, but every piece of information that contributes to the background of a story.

Worldbuilding does not have to be detailed. In many cases, worldbuilding is nothing more than a small change to the real world in order to fit the story in. A train station where there wasn’t one, or a slight change in the price of coffee to create a conflict. These stories can easily

¹ Taylor, Audrey Isabal & Ekman, Stefa,. “Notes towards a Critical Approach to Worlds and World-Building”, *Fafnir: Nordic Journal of Science Fiction and Fantasy Research*. Accessed Apr 2, 2025. <https://kau.diva-portal.org/smash/record.jsf?pid=diva2%3A1608962&dswid=8675>

² Temple, Emily, “In Defense of Worldbuilding”, <https://lithub.com/in-defense-of-worldbuilding/>

³ Tremblay, Kaitlin, “Collaborative Worldbuilding for Videogames”, Published 2023 by CRC Press,

⁴ Tremblay, Kaitlin, “Collaborative Worldbuilding for Videogames”.

be mistaken for taking place in the real world if the reader is not already familiar with the area they take place in, and is able to identify the differences. Lincoln Michel argues that “[i]n a perfectly executed work of worldbuilding, there would be no gaps in the world for the reader to fill in,”⁵ where “worldbuilding” is specifically defined as the task of fully explaining a world, leaving nothing for the reader’s imagination. While that certainly can be true for epic fantasy and science fiction, those are only two genres out of many. Many types of stories don’t need more than a few lines of worldbuilding to support them. Any story wants the world around it built to a scale that makes sense for what it is. Michel is defining worldbuilding in a very narrow sense, missing the point that it can be as small or as large as needed for the story. He attempts to offer an alternative which he calls “worldconjuring,” where the writer will create only the details needed to suggest a larger world, and not actually make the larger world itself, though as Temple points out in her piece responding to Michel, this is still just worldbuilding itself, simply a different form of it—one that lets the reader participate in the process.

Worldbuilding isn’t something done entirely by the author of a story. It is also something done by everyone who interacts with a story, as Jo Walton says in her article on reading science fiction and fantasy: “We talk about worldbuilding as something the writer does, but it’s also something the reader does, building the world from the clues.”⁶ A writer will sometimes gloss over details in a story such as how a tachyon drive works in order to get on with the story, trusting that the reader will either figure it out, or make a reasonable assumption that fills enough of the gap to leave them satisfied. This pushes some of the work of worldbuilding onto the reader, leaving the author free to focus on the story rather than the minutia of the world. Leaving the small details out is an example of building only the necessary amount of the world

⁵ Michel, Lincoln, “Against Worldbuilding”, Electric Lit. Accessed Sep 9, 2024, <https://electricliterature.com/against-worldbuilding/>

⁶ Walton, Jo, “SF Reading Protocols”, Reactor, <https://reactormag.com/sf-reading-protocols/>, Accessed Feb 14, 2025

for the story, and leaving the rest to be assumed to exist, even if it is never seen or mentioned. This is often seen in games like Dungeons and Dragons, where the players are able to tell stories and create parts of the world on their own alongside the game designer. This style of world co-creation relies on three primary features of the world to work: players making decisions about what to add to the world, a world that has space to be added to, and moderators to manage the added content.⁷ This means that the participants in a game or story can add their own interpretations of the world to it, as long as it fits within the world as determined by the moderators. In the case of written stories, the reader can only add information in their own imagination, or write their own stories, not add to the existing world.

Authors take different approaches to worldbuilding when creating stories, even in the same genre. George R.R. Martin often describes himself as a “gardener”, where he plants the seeds, and lets them grow into a story as he writes it, rather than an “architect”, who knows exactly how the story will be shaped before even writing the first word.⁸ In the first case, worldbuilding is done as the story is being written, and only as needed to support the narrative. Details that are not relevant to the story are often left out or left to be filled in by the reader’s imagination rather than explicitly stated in the text. This is the approach that lets readers fill in pieces themselves that the author did not include. An “architect”, on the other hand, is more likely to have spent hours building the world and details surrounding the story before writing a single word. They probably know how much a slice of bread costs in their capital city, even if there hasn’t been a single scene set there. This removes some agency from the reader, but can make for a fulfilling experience of uncovering details about the world hidden in the text, and

⁷ Acharya, Devi & Wardrip-Fruin, Noah, “Building Worlds Together”, <https://dl.acm.org/doi/pdf/10.1145/3337722.3337748>

⁸ Martin, George R.R., “A Winter Garden”, <https://georgerrmartin.com/notablog/2022/07/08/a-winter-garden/>, Accessed Apr 29, 2025

piecing facts together like a puzzle to learn about the world. In the opposite direction, some stories are intentionally set in our world with no changes made. This isn't an example of a lack of worldbuilding, instead the writer is trusting the reader to do the work of filling in what they already know about our world to be the backdrop. As Walton said earlier about readers doing worldbuilding while reading science fiction and fantasy, they also do work while reading realism or historical fiction, where the world is the one we all already know.⁹ The world exists in the mind of the reader even if it isn't written on the page. This can be used to great effect when a story needs to focus on plot or character development and not take time explaining every detail of the world we already live in. This is also often seen in sequels, where the world has been explained in a previous book and the reader is trusted to know the important details already.

Worldbuilding as a process is used to shape the context around a story in order to persuade the reader that the events in the story are plausible. A story told without worldbuilding would be a series of events in a void, actions taken without the context of why they matter or what they cause. In his 1947 essay "On Fairy-Stories", J. R. R. Tolkien mentions the idea of a world with a green sun—clearly not the world we live in, but instead a possible fantasy world.

To make a Secondary World inside which the green sun will be credible, commanding Secondary Belief, will probably require labour and thought, and will certainly demand a special skill, a kind of elvish craft. Few attempt such difficult tasks. But when they are attempted and in any degree accomplished then we have a rare achievement of Art: indeed narrative art, storymaking in its primary and most potent mode.¹⁰

He argues that a green sun on its own is not enough to convince others of the world, and that more has to be done to build out the world that would have a green sun. Doing this work to

⁹ Walton, Jo, "SF Reading Protocols"

¹⁰ Tolkien, J. R. R., "On Fairy-Stories", 1947, 23.

answer these questions is worldbuilding, and Tolkien argues it is necessary to build out a world complete enough to answer questions like these in order to write a fantasy world. Tolkien says that fantasy is in particular the “making or glimpsing of Other-worlds”¹¹, that to be a true fantasy it must involve a world that is not our own, what he calls a “Secondary World”, as opposed to our own “Primary World”. He also says that this was the purpose of fairytales and old stories of magic and dragons and wonder—to create and share worlds that do not exist. This is where the storytellers must build a world around their stories, or perhaps as part of their stories. In *Building Imaginary Worlds*, Mark Wolf underscores this very point: “Worlds can exist without stories, but stories cannot exist without a world.”¹² The creation of either a secondary world or a space within our primary world for a story to take place is necessary for it to make sense. Thus worldbuilding is a key component of telling any story.

Defining LARP

Worldbuilding is a major component of the story and design of Live Action RolePlay (LARP) games—a form of roleplaying game that takes place in a physical space where both the players and Non-Player Characters (NPCs) are played by real people. The games are a form of interactive theater where the players, NPCs, and game runners work together to tell a story. There are usually no dice to determine success or failure; instead the results of a player’s actions rely on their real skill at the task they are attempting. This means that a player’s real-world skills affect their success in the game. This can be incredibly rewarding for players, but can also be frustrating, as games are often known for allowing players to use game mechanics to do normally impossible actions, such as casting spells.LARPs that rely on real world skills are referred to as

¹¹ Tolkien, J. R. R., “On Fairy-Stories”, 20.

¹² Wolf, Mark J.P.. *Building Imaginary Worlds*. New York: Routledge. 2012.

“What You See is What You Get,” or WYSIWYG games. Even though the game relies on real-world skills the world of the game takes place in what can be called the “magic circle”¹³. It is essentially a non-physical space where each player is pretending to be someone else, and within that space the players can take actions as their characters that they cannot, or would not, take in the real world. It is rarely represented by a physical space, but instead is a state of being in the world. A player could be outside the magic circle when they arrive, but after putting on their costume enter it and be in the LARP while remaining in the same physical space. SomeLARPs will use separate spaces to represent this, such as having an Out-Of-Character storage area for player belongings, or specified In-Character areas to roleplay in, but more often the line blurs.

In an effort to define what a LARP is Eirik Fatland and Lars Wingård arrived at, “A LARP is a meeting between people who, through their roles, relate to each other in a fictional world.”¹⁴ The game mechanics and historical settings that LARP is most known for are not necessary for the medium. All that is needed is people playing together and pretending to be someone other than who they are in the real world. They note that all participants must be aware that they are in a LARP, otherwise it is simply one person deceiving another about reality. Once participants are in agreement they can begin to play and interact with each other and with the game. As long as they are interacting with each other through the lens of the game, they are LARPing.

¹³ Järvelä, Simo, “How Real is LARP?”, https://www.researchgate.net/profile/Simo-Jaervelae-2/publication/337482278_How_Real_Is_Larp/links/5ddae82392851c1fedaf54eb/How-Real-Is-Larp.pdf

¹⁴ Fatland, Eirik & Wingård, Lars, “The Dogma 99 Manifesto”, Nordic Larp, <https://nordiclarp.org/w/images/c/c2/2003-As.Larp.Grows.Up.pdf>

Boffer LARP

LARP games can take a few forms. The most widely known form is Adventure LARP, or a Boffer LARP, where participants use fake weapons (such as foam swords called boffers) and go on an adventure to slay a dragon, rescue a prisoner, and more. These games often go on for multiple “events”, each one ranging in length from a day to a full weekend, over the course of months to years. Players in these events frequently design their own character and play them consistently over the course of the story. These games can also rely heavily on simulated combat to solve problems, the most common form of which is boffer sword fighting. This simulated combat is designed to avoid any actual injury to the players. Some examples of medieval BofferLARPs include NERO, a US-based LARP that spans the country; Bicolline, a LARP based in Quebec; Amtgard, another US-spanning LARP.

While it might seem odd to place such a strong focus on combat, especially when the goal is to avoid any injury, combat can actually serve as a far more nuanced conflict resolution method than it first appears. Zoë Antoinette Eddy, a WPI Professor in the Global School, says in her paper that “the physicality of combat and the narrative stakes of fights create a unique opportunity for creative, supportive collaboration.”¹⁵ Players can physically act out the actions that their characters take in a way that is much more personal than the theater of the mind that gets used in tabletop games, or the limited set of actions that video games allow. Combat is not a violent action intended to cause harm, but a physical activity to resolve the game’s story arc or conflict. Some games are set up as narrative focused quests where the players are sent on a mission to defeat an enemy or retrieve an artifact, and some are set up more as tournaments or war maneuvers. Tournaments and war maneuvers are usually done as player vs player events,

¹⁵Eddy, Zoë A., “(Role)playing soldier: LARP, simulated combat, and gender at war”, *Culture, Theory, and Critique*, Accessed Mar 6, 2025, (1–2): 212–40. doi:10.1080/14735784.2024.2336451.

where players are in direct competition with each other. As you would see in a martial arts tournament, the goal isn't to hurt the opponents, but to compete to the best of your ability. In quest-focused events the players are usually fighting against NPC groups set up by the quest designer to oppose the players. These NPC groups usually do not fight to the best of their ability, but will instead scale their fighting to tell a good story for the players. The goal can be to defeat the NPCs, but more often this goal would be secondary after the primary goal of reaching a certain in-world location or retrieving an object.

Theater LARP

The second prominent LARP form is the Theater or Parlor LARP, where players are given a character to play by the game designer and must follow the rules that are designed for them. These LARP games often focus on puzzle or mystery topics, or in some cases social issues in the world around them. TheseLARPs have no direct combat, and if a situation needs to be resolved beyond characters talking, they will use a mechanic such as cards or dice. MostLARPs of this style are “one-shot” stories rather than continuing campaigns, meaning that they are a single story told once, rather than a continuing world. This is very common in Nordic LARP, a style of LARP most commonly seen in Scandinavia, particularly Sweden and Finland. This style of game has grown into a full genre of LARP, and has differentiated itself from the older form of LARP by emphasizing “playing to lose”. Rather than players being placed in a hierarchy and trying to get the best result for themselves out of the game, they attempt to get the best result for the story at large, even if that means their character suffers personally.¹⁶ LARPs are usually

¹⁶ Fatland, Eirik & Montola, Markus, “The Blockbuster Formula - Brute Force Design in the Monitor Celestra and College of Wizardry”,<https://nordiclarp.org/2015/05/06/the-blockbuster-formula-brute-force-design-in-the-monitor-celestra-and-college-of-wizardry/>, Accessed Mar 25, 2025.

designed and run by a core set of game designers specific to that LARP. This core group runs either a long-running story over multiple years, or multiple one shot stories. In contrast to D&D, where each small game is run by a separate Game Master, often someone with no prior experience or training in running a game, these game runners are often experienced with designing interactive stories and have studied interactive design.

The Realms as a LARP

The LARP system I am using as the basis of my project is from a game called The Realms. The rule system it uses was originally based around the combat system used by the Society for Creative Anachronism (SCA), but has evolved since then.¹⁷ It is based in the New England area and was started by Shannon Slate around 1987, at which point it was known as The Realms of Wonder, or The Realms of Valehaven.¹⁸ The game has changed rule systems significantly throughout the years, such as the introduction of the magic system, the switch from Shannon being the only event runner to anyone being able to run events, and the changes to weapon construction rules—to make them lighter and safer. In its current form the Realms is a medieval fantasy boffer LARP with one major distinguishing feature: there is no central rules committee. Instead the rules and events are created and run by anyone in the game who wants to. This leads to many players running plots that vary wildly between simple conflict, and complex social interactions. It also allows plot runners to get far more creative than if they were the only plot running in the game. Players have options, and if they dislike one particular story, they can choose not to attend those events, instead playing only what they enjoy.

¹⁷ Diamond, Dan, “The Epic History of the Realms”.

¹⁸ Diamond, Dan, “The Epic History of the Realms”. View From Valehaven, Accessed Feb 23, 25.
<https://viewfromvalehaven.blogspot.com/2024/08/the-epic-history-of-realms.html>

The Realms is a boffer combat LAR which uses lightest touch instead of stronger blows. This can create an expectation in players that every event will include a form of combat. In fact, many players come to events only intending to participate in the boffer combat, not interested in the story or roleplaying at all. This leads to many events that might otherwise be more roleplay focused adding combat to entertain those players. Some event holders have chosen to add combat to events that could have run without them due to player expectations. It has also been used as an easier way to scale encounters for large groups of players. Combat is so much a part of the game that Out-of-Character practices have been set up specifically to practice combat, with almost no attention to any other skills. Practicing the in-game spellcasting system is nearly exclusively done in relation to combat where spellcasters will practice healing and support spells.

My LARP Design

In order to see how the worldbuilding our MQP group did would appear in a LARP format, I wrote a two-hour LARP quest set in a part of that world. I ran it during an event called Avalon Questing, where three people got to run a short quest each. The LARP system I used is one from the New England LARP called The Realms. The event took place at WPI in the Odeum, and the players of my quest were primarily WPI students and other new players to the Realms. During the quest I was acting as the Magic Marshal, which meant I was with the players, but not as an NPC; instead I was Out-of-Character and available to answer questions or resolve magic spells that can

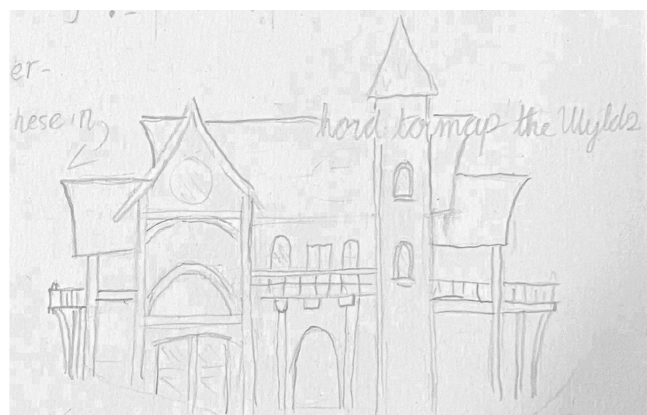


Figure 1. A sketch of the manor where the quest takes place

predict the future, or resolve PC actions. I set my LARP quest in the Fae Wilds of the world and centered the story around the murder and potential resurrection of one of the Dukes of Faerie, essentially the gods of that realm. Using a pre-existing LARP let me avoid creating characters for the players myself, instead relying on them already having characters to play that they could bring into this world.

I designed the quest to let the players make choices in the world that will affect it going forward. This is kept contained to the Fae Wilds of the world so as to prevent it from conflicting with the other projects my team made¹⁹, but my goal is to allow players to be the driving force behind changes in the Fae Wilds going forwards. My worldbuilding in this part of the world is focused on setting up pieces and characters in a way that they can be moved and changed as a result of player action, and planning multiple outcomes for any events that happen. I focused the design on maximizing player engagement with the world as a whole while trying to minimize or eliminate the need for boffer combat. Without a drive towards combat I hoped that players would take more time to engage with the world rather than just fighting enemies without thinking about why they were doing it. I was focused on trying to show a world through the LARP rather than building specific mechanics or “railroading” the players onto a specific path. They were free to interact with the world how they liked. My quest became *less* of a game where players had a set objective and were working to “win” the game and *more* of an experience where they could take any actions they wished, while the world moved around—and in response to—them. While I had prepared a couple of expected endings, there were more possibilities than I wrote down as the expected options. The lack of a set path to the goal led to more interaction and roleplay than just

¹⁹ As part of an IMGD MQP, our team made four separate projects set in the world that we built. The other three projects were a TTRPG, an audio drama, and a narrative archival research puzzle.

brute forcing a path to the end of the story. In some ways a part of the quest was more theater LARP than boffer LARP, with the players able to interact via roleplay and puzzle solving.

Design Challenges

I faced two main challenges during the design process of this quest: limiting combat in the encounters without detracting from player engagement, and creating the simulation of a space without physical props. While combat is not an inherently bad thing in LARP, it certainly can distract from other aspects of the experience. Both challenges caused me significant difficulty, and I solved the first challenge much better than the second. My design started the quest with what was effectively a coat check, but for the players's weapons instead of clothing. I wanted them to enter the quest without the comfort of being able to fight their way out of a problem. There were two reasons for this. I wanted to encourage alternate solutions for quests beyond fighting the enemies until there are no more enemies left, and I wanted to emphasize the world and story in a way that is much harder to see when combat is taking center stage on a quest. This can lead to players focusing on “winning” the game by defeating enemies in combat and therefore missing the subtle plot threads and social interactions that may be happening around them. This can be resolved by something referred to in the Nordic LARP scene as “playing to lose,”²⁰ where a player approaches the LARP not as a challenge to be defeated, but as an experience to participate in. The character they play may be more flawed or out of place in the setting—sacrificing an “advantage” in exchange for telling a better story. By forcing the players to give up their weapons I was hoping to force them into a similar situation, where character

²⁰ Fatland, Eirik & Montola, Markus, “The Blockbuster Formula - Brute Force Design in the Monitor Celestra and College of Wizardry”, <https://nordiclarp.org/2015/05/06/the-blockbuster-formula-brute-force-design-in-the-monitor-celestra-and-college-of-wizardry/>, Accessed Mar 25, 2025.

choices and flaws could take center stage rather than combat being the primary focus. This is especially noticeable in the Realms, where boffer combat is one the most common interactions on a quest. Taking that away led to more players trying secondary actions and finding other parts of the world to interact with beyond fighting enemies. In addition to finding new methods of interacting, players also had a chance to slow down and engage with the world and story. Instead of worldbuilding being a backdrop to a mechanics-focused game, the worldbuilding became the game itself.

My second primary challenge was creating a space that convincingly simulated a manor in the real location I had to run the quest in. The event space I had was the Odeum at WPI, a large hall divided into three smaller rooms, with linoleum floors and modern lights, switches, and objects around it. Those modern objects made it difficult to create a convincing illusion of a fantasy manor house without taking excessive time and energy to create props that would cover up a majority of the walls. I ended up with only minimal props that were needed for NPCs and the necessary player interactions. Turning the lights lower in the room helped, but the room still appeared mostly like the event space it truly was. While some amount of theater of the mind on the part of the players certainly helped, I don't know if it was quite enough. In her blog post on her experience at an immersive theater class, Emily Short mentions that “[they have] a luxury here that game designers don't: there's nothing specific that a Punchdrunk production must communicate to the audience.”²¹ This is similarly true for LARP: the players are fully in the space and allowed to interact with it. While some leniency can be allowed as LARP leans more towards immersive theater than video games do, it is still interactive enough that stray objects or missed details can affect the experience. On the other hand, creating the “magic circle” of a

²¹ Short, Emily, “Worldbuilding in Immersive Theatre, and the Punchdrunk style”, Blog, Accessed Mar 4, 2025, <https://emshort.blog/2018/03/20/worldbuilding-in-immersive-theatre/>

LARP doesn't need the physical space to be decorated in the same way. That works by having enough players together in a space that they can convince themselves that the world around them is real. The world around them becomes the one that has been built in their heads, even if they don't physically see the evidence of that. In this way the lack of physical props and decorations didn't cause any problems because there were enough players with enough investment already that they were able to let themselves become part of the story, and based on player feedback I received most of the players did feel immersed in the world.

Results of the LARP

My LARP was designed in a way that meant relying a lot on the people playing the Non-Player Characters (NPCs) to understand their role and follow it. This meant that a lot of the details of the world were left up to interpretation by the people playing the roles. Rather than giving the NPCs particular lines to say, I let them improvise lines based on a character outline, as they felt would best fit the world. With my emphasis on the low-combat design, this made the quest into something resembling an improv theater show.

The players mostly did well engaging with the plot (which can be found in Appendix A) and worldbuilding of the event. I spoke to some of the more involved players after the event to see what they thought, and gauge how much they had learned about the world. One player, who plays Squire Margaret August, said that "I definitely got a sense that there was a larger world," when they were talking to the NPCs and reading the documents handed out. Due to the large number of documents, they were not able to fully comprehend everything, but there was clearly something there. In general, people did think that there was a little bit too much information for the short time (only two hours) provided for the quest. The information overload was not helped

by players failing to write down the information they gained. Another player, playing Captain Bogen Goldforge, said “having the NPC be like 'maybe one of you should start writing this down' [would have helped the players keep track of plot-relevant information better]”. The players got too caught up in the talking to remember to write down what they learned, making it hard to share the information to others. However, in the end the players did learn enough from the NPCs and documents to successfully complete the quest

Others enjoyed being able to come at the world from different angles. Some people spent a lot of time talking to the other Dukes after they committed the murder, and one person, who plays Jasper Sherwood, said “It was nice that that was an option, to get a different perspective on the world.” They chose to engage with a different part of the worldbuilding, but still had a chance to find a part of the world that interested them. The players that engaged with the puzzle the most liked it, and enjoyed how it forced them to speak to NPCs and collect information. Another player, who plays Voutiá, said, “The murder-not-quite-mystery element of it was really appealing to me. I also got a lot from the larger world, between interacting with all the NPCs and the library notes.” They were the player who “completed” the ritual at the end, transferring the power from the former Duke to his daughter. At the end, the players chose to transfer the Duke’s power to his daughter, creating a new Duchess in the world. They were active participants in the story and world rather than just outside observers.

The second key feature of the quest—the low combat design—also drew quite a few players in. While some people got thrown off at first, many of them enjoyed how it changed the primary method of interaction with the villains. One player, playing a character called Tom Fulerey, said that it made the interactions with the enemies much more interesting because there was no physical way to attack them. Some players did wish that there was a way to smuggle

weapons past the guard rather than being entirely stripped of them. Voutiá said that “I think it would be more interesting to make it a bit more of a game for the players, like having people see if they can sneak a boot dagger in like kids sneaking candy into a movie theater.” While the goal



Figure 2. Players during the LARP

was to fully remove combat as an option, it also proved a more jarring experience than I first expected to take away the weapons. Another player found that they “liked it as a tone setting thing,” where it made it clear that fighting was not the correct first step anywhere. Overall it worked out well to set the tone, but the limited NPC options later in the quest made it less effective at that time. One person, who played Jasper, said that “Even people who only like fighting can and should gain from not having their weapons and having to think

through a quest.” While some players don’t always choose to engage in the story and roleplay, it is still part of the game and I wanted it brought to the forefront as opposed to being just a reason to be fighting.

With this LARP quest I chose to write a story with no combat in it using a system that is primarily based around combat. While the initial reason I chose this system is the convenience it offered as I am already involved in the game and had help setting up the event, I did choose to maintain many of the rules from the Realms system intentionally. The Realms LARP system allows anyone who plays to run an event and tell a story, rather than having a centralized plot team.²² This freedom meant that I could tell a story of my own without involving former history

²² Diamond, Dan, “The Epic History of the Realms: Part 2”. The View from Valehaven, <https://viewfromvalehaven.blogspot.com/2024/12/the-epic-history-of-realms-chapter-two.html>, Accessed Apr 29, 2025

from the Realms, while still allowing players to enter with characters they have already made. I chose to work without combat to emphasize the story and world in the LARP, rather than rely on combat as a filler mechanic.

Lessons Learned

Most of what went wrong can be attributed to limited focus and energy leading up to the quest, not to actual design limitations. I should have understood better that being a college student in my senior year with other classes would limit my creative abilities, but even so, it was worse than I expected. That led to fewer physical props and puzzle testing and design than I wanted. It also meant I did not have the time I needed to plan NPC roles with people ahead of time, leaving them without some necessary information to play the role as well as I would have liked. This left me needing to stay near the center of the quest and supervise it rather than lurking around the edges and only participating as the magic marshal (a role where I answer magic questions or resolve effects that the PCs cannot resolve on their own). The roles I had set up for the NPCs were unusual as far as Realms NPCs go, and so the people helping had to adjust on the fly. This meant that most of their experience was not as helpful, though some of them were more experienced with roleplay and improv and could make it work. The lack of briefing wasn't entirely a detriment however, as leaving the NPCs open to tell their own bits of a story meant that I could get a lot more worldbuilding communicated to the players than I had time or ability to write. In one case, one of the NPCs was able to fill in the missing Duke that I had accidentally forgotten to write in, and created the Duke of Stories, something far more interesting than I would have come up with. This added some lore to the world that otherwise would not have been

there. Letting the NPCs improvise their responses is not always a bad thing, but in my case it was perhaps too freeform for the type of quest I was running.

In addition, the primary puzzle of gathering information was functional, but required too much information to complete easily in the time required. There were multiple pages of documents, as well as three rituals to decode and sort. While that amount of information was relevant to the quest, the players could not finish collecting and reading in the time provided, especially with the pressure of the Dukes and Duchesses returning to interfere. Much of the feedback I got was that having a break in the event would have helped by giving the players time to sort through the information. If I had to do this over again I would instead rely on more puzzle mechanics, and then a simpler description of the rituals that was handed out easily.

A New Design Concept

To correct the mistakes of my last design, I worked on a design concept for a follow-up LARP quest, set in the same world and taking place after the events of the first quest. The next quest is set in the forest surrounding the Manor that the first quest took place in, and it would be played at night. Despite the PCs efforts, the Manor has become overrun with monsters created by the other Dukes and shrouded in darkness. The players will be led back to the realm by one of the locals who manages to open a temporary portal. They will then be tasked with setting up a small base of operations by gathering a special type of flame and setting up beacons to create safety.

The primary improvement offered by this quest is a better setting: a forest instead of an opulent manor. By setting the quest in a location I can easily get in the real world, I avoid

needing to spend time on set dressing. A dark forest is easy to get at almost any of the common LARP sites that the Realms community uses, giving me easy access to my required location. That also allows me to use a few simple props involving light which will stand out against the darkness and draw more attention to the parts I have spent time on than the parts I did very little with. The primary focus of the light sources would be the special flame props that the PCs need to collect, the portal archway into the realm, and the monster costumes. Small bits of light will stand out against the darkness and draw attention away from the less well-made props.

The second improvement over the previous design is the focus on action rather than PC/NPC interaction. The players will be venturing out into the darkness to retrieve the flames, rather than relying on conversation with the NPCs to gain knowledge. While there will be NPCs with knowledge at the campsite, they will not be the focus of the quest. However, interacting with them may reward the PCs with helpful information or items to assist with setting up the flame beacons. There will not be large amounts of text to read, as the locals are intentionally designed to be a species that communicates visually rather than with words or written text.

I plan to maintain the non-reliance on combat as a feature, but this time using stealth or speed as the backup mechanic rather than roleplay and NPC interaction. This will still let players avoid fighting and make the peaceful choice, while adding combat as an option for players who prefer it. There will be a few monsters that cannot be fought and must be avoided, but for the most part combat will be a backup option, replaced in this event by stealth or careful planning rather than through roleplay or puzzle solving. I reintroduced optional combat for two reasons: some players will try to seek out combat even if there isn't any and having a place to direct them will help avoid derailing the quest, and this part of the story is meant to have a very different tone. It's leaning more towards horror and stealth than puzzles. Avoiding combat will remain the

optimal route, but giving the players a chance to defend themselves will give them slightly more agency in the open world of this quest. I have included both a table of the design features for both quests below, and some initial design documents in Appendix B.

Design Feature	A Murder in the Manor	Haunting of Levenstone
Combat Avoidance	High	Optional
Stealth	None	High
Roleplay	High	Low - lore only
Puzzles	High	Average/optional
Decorated Space	None	The Woods
Lore	High	Medium/optional
World Interaction	Medium	Medium/high

Table 1. A comparison of design features between my first quest and planned second quest.

Conclusion

When starting this project I was trying to explore how to express worldbuilding through a LARP quest. As I designed the quest I realized that the combat-heavy LARP system was contrasting with the focus on worldbuilding and story. I needed to find a way to force players to engage with the content in new ways rather than falling back on combat. This evolved into taking the players' weapons away at the start of the quest, though they did get to recover them later as the quest got more "dangerous" to the characters. I found out that LARP quests that traditionally have boffer combat are often hard to adapt to avoid it. Players have expectations that are hard to counteract, but in some cases they find new ways of engaging in "combat", even if it's through words, or the LARP's spellcasting system, rather than through physical combat.

The desire for tactile interaction can then be re-focused onto the puzzle components and choices about where to be in the space. However, if you can provide a solid amount of content to re-focus even the combat heavy players into, then lacking combat doesn't necessarily prevent them from having fun, it just makes them approach the event in a new way. Even in a LARP where combat is normally a primary focus, it is still possible to make a fun event without combat as long as the mechanics, story, and interactivity are strong enough.

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Appendices

Appendix A: Story Summary

My quest was a short murder mystery/ritual puzzle where the players needed to collect information about the victim to attempt to resurrect him. The story was set in the Fae plane of a world our MQP team had developed earlier in the project, where intent and belief ruled over logic and rules. It began when the player characters (also called PCs) received a letter—in the form of the event announcement—inviting them to a dinner at a Duke of Faerie’s manor. Upon arriving and checking in their weapons at the door they entered the parlor of the manor, only to find that someone else had arrived before them. Five other Dukes and Duchesses of the realm had arrived, and were accusing the host, Hala del’Rhomar, of betraying them hundreds of years ago. After a short confrontation, they stepped forward and killed him, at which point the PCs attempted to confront them and prevent them from leaving. However, the Dukes and Duchesses were far more powerful, and simply left.

Following this, Duke Hala’s daughter entered the room and found her father dead. After a brief explanation from the PCs, she led them to the garden where she declared vengeance against her father’s killers, and told the PCs that to help they needed to try to bring him back. She pointed them at Duke Hala’s study, where he kept records of rituals to call the spirits of the dead back, or transfer the titles they held to another.

In the study, the PCs encountered a collection of spirits and ghosts who were holding on to information, and had to talk to them and help them finish their learning in order to get fragments of information from them. They took some time collecting the information and decoding it, sometimes being afflicted with curses while they did so, until they found the three possible rituals they could use. During this process the Dukes and Duchesses started to return, investigating what the PCs were doing.

Once the PCs knew what they were looking for, they quickly made a decision and travelled to the ritual room to perform a ritual. Despite being nearly ready, they almost fell victim to their enemies stopping their progress before they quickly called out the correct truth and bound Duke Hala's power into his daughter, allowing her to take up her father's place and banish the other Dukes and Duchesses from her land.

Appendix B: The Haunting of Levenstone Design Docs

Scene Title: Portal Opening/Approach	NPCs Needed: 1 + 5-7	PC Group Size: <30	Authors: Owen Lacey
Story			
What is <u>motivating the PCs</u> to engage with this scene? The players are being asked for help by a strange being who seems unable to speak. They are communicating about a camp in a darkness that they need help reinforcing, and people lost in the shadows.			
What has happened <u>before the PCs enter</u> the scene? What is happening <u>as they enter</u>? The darkness has overrun the entire area, and the campfire is dark. Shadows are attacking and enveloping people.			
What <u>challenges</u> do the PCs face? Why can't this scene be resolved by the NPCs alone? The players need to save the NPCs from the shadows, and use light to push the enemies away from the camp. This can be done without combat, though this first time means losing some NPCs for a time. The PCs can light the campfire (hopefully a real one) and establish a little bit of safety, and probably raise some of the dead Antlered around the camp.			
What are the <u>expected endings</u> for this scene? How will the PCs know if they have <u>succeeded or failed</u>? The PCs need the camp (relatively) safe, and at least the guide Antlered alive to inform them of the soul flames that will repel the darkness even further.			
Setup			
Key NPCs: The Guide Shadows (first variant) Dead Antlered	Key Location and Set Dressing Notes: The camp is centered around a fire. There's not much here, maybe a few "tents"		Key Props: Antlered Costume Fake fire if not a real one. Some notes on soul flames
Mechanics			
Combat Level Moderate ▾	Mechanics & Other Info that All NPCs Need to Know The shadows will be repelled by light at this point. Any sort of light spell or effect will keep them back from the person holding it, and anyone immediately nearby. Treat it as a ward that pushes people back. The campfire keeps the entire camp safe.		
Magic Marshal Involvement: Low ▾			

Scene Title: The Lost Temple	NPCs Needed: 2 + 10	PC Group Size: <30	Authors: Owen L
Story			
What is <u>motivating the PCs</u> to engage with this scene? The players are searching for the soul flame lanterns to protect the camp and drive back the darkness. They have either seen a path in the woods, or have been told of an old temple deep in the forest that once held a soul flame.			
What has happened <u>before the PCs enter</u> the scene? What is happening <u>as they enter</u>? The temple has fallen into ruins, and with the darkness surrounding it there is no evidence that anything is left inside. Between the players and the temple are two “Xenomorph” style monsters prowling the darkness, but they’re not directly in the way, just a warning to stay on the path.			
What <u>challenges</u> do the PCs face? Why can’t this scene be resolved by the NPCs alone? The temple door is locked, and the soul flame inside is magically repressed. The players will need to open the door and break the wards to find the flame. Once they have it, they will need to get the flame back to camp while still lit, but it might take some time to charge first.			
What are the <u>expected endings</u> for this scene? How will the PCs know if they have <u>succeeded or failed</u>? The players need to retrieve the flame and return it to camp. If they can’t get it there while lit, they can bring the dead flame and light it another way, but an ideal solution involves getting it back lit.			
Setup			
Key NPCs: 2x “Xenomorph” 10+ Shadows	Key Location and Set Dressing Notes: A locked door Runes around the temple	Key Props: Rune puzzle pieces. Soul Flame Flame Altar	
Mechanics			
Expected Combat Level Moderate ▾	Mechanics & Other Info that All NPCs Need to Know While lit, no monster will approach the soul flame, or anyone in the group holding it. It will actively drive them back, unlike a ward, and is not directional. If the soul flame goes out it no longer repels the monsters. The temple isn’t a safe area, but nothing naturally is near it or attacking.		
Expected Magic Marshal Involvement: Moderate ▾			